

Read before your first session

How to run your program.

The exercises matter less than what you do with them. Without progression there is no reason for your body to change, and progression only works if you run it the same way every session. Read this once, properly.

THE WHOLE SYSTEM

- 1 Stop every set at the RIR target on its row. Never fail a rep, and never grind one out.
- 2 On exercises marked **RPT**, your heaviest set is first, then you drop the weight 5-10% for the second set.
- 3 On exercises marked **SS**, you use the same weight for both sets.
- 4 Add reps until you reach the top of the rep range in **both** sets. Then add the smallest weight increment available and build the reps back up.

That is the entire program. Everything below explains how to do those four things properly.

1. How hard to take each set

RIR means reps in reserve: the number of reps you could still have done when you stopped. The number next to each exercise is your target, and it is not the same on every exercise.

The goal is to do every rep you can while still being confident you can complete the rep you are doing. The moment you are no longer sure the next rep will go up, the set is over. That is what 0-1 RIR means in practice.

Two things you never do. **You do not fail a rep.** Getting stuck halfway up costs you the rest of the session and buys you nothing. **You do not grind.** If a rep crawls, takes several seconds and empties you out, that was one rep too far. You will feel it in every exercise that follows.

-  You racked it with three or more clean reps still in you
Too early. The set was too far from failure to do much.
-  You stopped because you were no longer sure the next rep would go up
Correct. This is the target on every set marked 0-1 RIR.
-  Your last rep ground out over several seconds
One rep too far. It cost you the rest of the session.
-  You attempted a rep and could not complete it
Too far. There is no reason to fail a rep on this program.

RIR 1 The big movements stop a rep earlier

On these you stop while **certain** you had one more rep in you. Not hopeful. Certain. And you should be equally certain that the rep you left would have been ugly: the slow grinder that takes everything out of you, or one you could only have finished by letting your technique go.

The reasons are not really about getting pinned under a bar. **Technique breaks down before the muscle does**, and a rep rescued with a rounded back or a shifted hip is where injuries come from. **Heavy compounds are also expensive**. A set of leg press taken to true failure wipes you out far more than one taken to 1 RIR, and everything later in the session pays for it. On machines it is often hard to tell where true failure even is, so aiming at it means going past it.

Every squat-type movement, hip hinge and hip thrust is in this group, along with barbell and dumbbell pressing, overhead work, weighted pull-ups and chin-ups, barbell rows and skullcrushers. The target is listed next to every exercise in your program, so you never have to remember which is which.

2. The two set models

Every exercise in your program is marked RPT or SS. The mark tells you what to do with the weight between sets, and nothing else changes.

RPT Reverse Pyramid Training

Your heaviest set comes first, while you are fresh. Then you reduce the weight 5-10% for the second set. Used on your compound lifts and anything else loaded heavily enough to warrant it.

Incline Barbell Press, 2 sets of 6-8

Set 1 60 kg × 8 **TOP OF RANGE**

Set 2 57.5 kg × 8 **TOP OF RANGE**

Each set is taken to your RIR target. The weight drops just enough to keep you inside the same rep range as fatigue builds.

If you kept the same weight for both sets, your reps would fall away on the second, or you would have to hold back on the first to survive it. RPT keeps you inside the target range and close to your limit on every set, which is what avoids junk volume: sets too far from failure to be worth doing.

SS Straight Sets

Same weight across both sets. Used on isolation exercises and smaller muscles that recover well between sets, where an RPT drop would leave you lifting almost nothing by the last set.

Dumbbell Lateral Raise, 2 sets of 10-15

Set 1 10 kg × 14

Set 2 10 kg × 10

Your reps drop across sets and that is expected. You hold the load and work on adding reps session to session.

3. How you progress: multi-set double progression

This is the same on every exercise, RPT or SS. It is called double progression because you progress two things in a fixed order: first reps, then weight. Never both at once.

1 Build reps

Keep the weight exactly where it is and add reps session to session. You are trying to reach the top number of the rep range in **both sets**, not just the first one.

↓ only once both sets are at the top of the range

2 Add weight

Increase by the smallest increment available, on both sets. Your reps will drop back toward the bottom of the range. That is not a setback, it is the whole mechanism.

↓ now go back to step 1 and build the reps back up

Worked through in full, on an exercise prescribed as 2 sets of 6-8 reps.

Workout 1

Set 1 60 kg × 7
Set 2 57.5 kg × 8 TOP OF RANGE

No weight increase. Set 2 reached 8, but set 1 stopped at 7. You need one more rep there before anything changes. Next session you attack the same weights.

Workout 2

Set 1 60 kg × 8 TOP OF RANGE
Set 2 57.5 kg × 8 TOP OF RANGE

Both sets are at the top of the range. You have earned the increase. Next session, add the smallest increment available to both sets. On a barbell that is usually 2.5 kg.

Workout 3

Set 1 62.5 kg × 7
Set 2 60 kg × 7

The extra 2.5 kg cost you a rep on each set, which is exactly what should happen. You are now back in step 1, building reps at a heavier load than you were handling three sessions ago. That is the progress.

Straight sets work the same way. Nothing about the two steps changes, only the fact that the load is the same across both sets.

Lateral Raise, 2 sets of 10-15 · long-term progression

Workout 1 10 kg × 14, 10
Workout 2 10 kg × 15, 11
...
Workout 12 10 kg × 15, 15 TOP OF RANGE
Workout 13 12.5 kg × 11, 10

Same load in both sets, adding reps each session. When both sets hit the top of the rep range, the next session moves up in load by the smallest increment and the rep count drops back a bit. Each progression cycle might take several weeks.

Dumbbell exercises drop more reps

A dumbbell exercise loads both hands, so the smallest increment is doubled. Going up 2.5 kg per hand is a 5 kg jump in total, which is why dumbbell exercises are given wider rep ranges in your program. Expect to lose three or four reps after an increase rather than one or two.

Incline Dumbbell Press, 2 sets of 6-10

Set 1 30 kg × 10 TOP OF RANGE

Set 2 27.5 kg × 10 TOP OF RANGE

Both sets at the top, so you go up 2.5 kg per hand next session.
Loads shown are per hand.

The session after

Set 1 32.5 kg × 6

Set 2 30 kg × 7

Reps fell by three to four because the total load went up by 5 kg.
The wider rep range exists to absorb exactly this. Build back to 10 across both sets to earn the next increase.

This is not training by feel

Before every set you check what you did last time on that exercise and you try to beat it, by a rep or by an increment. Without a written record of every set you cannot do that, and without that there is no progression. This is what the ShredSmart app is for.

4. Warming up

Before the **first** exercise for each muscle group, work up to your first working set. Three quick sets, minimal rest between them, just enough time to change the weight.

Warm-up, when your first working set is 60 kg

Set 1 30 kg × 5

Set 2 45 kg × 3

Set 3 55 kg × 2

Roughly 50%, 75% and 90% of your working weight. Move through them with no real rest, then rest 2-3 minutes before your first working set.

For later exercises hitting a muscle you have already warmed up, you do not need to repeat this. For small isolation work the full protocol is overkill: one set to feel the movement and get acquainted with the weight is enough.